While Ratan recognized the selfless services of the hotel staff, others said that Krishna Kumar and he were no less dedicated. Noshir Sanjana, the group security manager of the Taj, remarks, ‘Ratan Tata and Krishna Kumar are heroes’; they were closely involved in the salvage operations and rendered virtually every type of assistance and succour to those affected.

‘Atithi Devo Bhava’

An enduring theme of Indian culture is *‘Atithi devo bhava’* or ‘The guest is god’. This perhaps could not have found greater expression than at the Taj that fateful night. The staff did not hide or flee, although many of them could have. It would have been unfair to blame them if they had run away to save their lives in an act of self-preservation. But they morphed into guardians, formed human shields to protect their guests, escorted them to safety and came back to save more, knowing that a few may not return—and some did not. Many were befuddled by their extraordinary sense of service. Several reasons were proffered, but none was a complete explanation. The closest is that the staff were energized by the deep sense of loyalty the Tata companies evoke among its employees and by their alignment with the philosophical foundation of the group.

They defied the stereotype that the ‘natural human instinct at a time of terror … is to flee’. The sounds of grenades and bullets did not deter them. Each one was focused on getting their guests to safety. ‘There was not a single person who did not rise to do their duty,’ Krishna Kumar later recalled to *The Spectator* with pride. The vice chairman also recalled to Rohit Deshpande—who did a study on the Taj employees after the events of 26/11—that the staff were aware of all the back exits through which they could have easily made good their escape. Instead, as Deshpande says, they ‘instinctively did the right thing. And in the process, some of them, unfortunately, gave their lives to save guests’.

Even Ratan found this incredible. ‘I can’t explain it,’ he remarked to Deshpande. ‘There were no manuals. There were no instructions for what should be done in the circumstances. And so, what seems to have happened is individuals, from the waiters to the managers of the restaurants, all had this goal of let’s get the guests to safety.’ All who came to know about the attack moved instinctively towards their ‘temple’ that was under assault and played their part to protect it.